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Complete the Circuit: Dew, Depth, and a Simple Will

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Fourth day of Sukkot · Third day of Chol HaMoed in Eretz Yisrael · Second day of Chol HaMoed in the Diaspora
Ushpizin: Moshe Rabbeinu (Chabad pairing: the Mitteler Rebbe)
Yahrtzeit: R. Nachman of Breslov, 5571 (1810)
Chai Tishrei — life into the month

The Daily Learning Portions

The year-round Daily Learning Portions remain the foundation. What follows is the seasonal layer only.

- **Chumash:** Vezot Haberachah, 3rd aliyah — Devarim 33:13–17 (the blessing of Yosef)
- **Festival kriah (Eretz Yisrael, 4th day of Sukkot):** Bamidbar 29:23–31 (offerings of the fourth day)
- **Tehillim:** 88–89
- **Tanya:** Iggeret HaKodesh, middle of Epistle 22
- **Rambam (3 chapters):** Hilchot Mikvaot 2–4
- **Rambam (1 chapter):** Hilchot Gerushin 8
- **Sefer HaMitzvot:** Positive Commandment 109 — immersion in a mikveh
- **Hayom Yom, Tishrei 18:** Recite both *Om ani chomah* and *Adon HaMoshia*, but circle only once; say *hosha'ana* before and after the letters the chazzan chants aloud; begin the loud recitation from *samech* or *ayin*; complete a full circuit, ending at *tav*

Customs of the day. Eat in the sukkah. Take the Four Species (not Shabbat). Hallel, Hoshanot, Musaf, Ya'aleh VeYavo. Chabad: no tefillin on Chol HaMoed. Simchat Beit HaSho'evah continues. Because 15 Tishrei 5787 fell on Shabbat, the Hoshanah omitted then is made up today in the pattern the Hayom Yom records: two hymns, one circuit.

I. The Day Itself

Eighteen is *chai*. Chai Elul gives life to the work of Elul. Chai Tishrei, the Rebbe taught, is asked to give life to Tishrei — to the Days of Awe already passed and to the joy still in front of us, through Hoshana Rabbah, Shemini Atzeret, and Simchat Torah. The fourth night of Sukkot is already a night of Simchat Beit HaSho'evah. On the eighteenth of the month the joy is not a decoration on the festival. It is the festival's pulse.

The guest in the sukkah today is Moshe. Chabad pairs him with the Mitteler Rebbe. Both names point to *binah* that does not remain in the head: Moshe brings the word down until it can be spoken by a nation; the Mitteler Rebbe opens understanding until it can be lived. The blessing we read in Chitas is not Moshe's own tribe. It is Yosef's. The man of the Tent blesses the man of the field and the storehouse. Transmission is the day's work.

R. Nachman's histalkut on this date is not a footnote. Simple joy, *hitbodedut*, and refusal of despair belong at the table with Moshe's blessing and the willow's circuit.

II. Vezot Haberachah 3rd: Yosef's Land, From Dew to the Deep

> *UleYosef amar: Mevorechet Hashem artzo, mimmeged shamayim mital, umittehom rovetzet tachat. And of Yosef he said: Blessed of Hashem is his land — with the precious yield of heaven, with dew, and with the deep that couches beneath. (Devarim 33:13)*

Rashi reads the blessing as the land itself: dew from above, the tehom from below, the yield of sun and moons, the first of the ancient mountains and the everlasting hills, the fullness of the earth, and then — not produce at all — *retzon Shochni sneh*, the goodwill of the One who dwelt in the bush. The climax is not fertility. It is favor from the G-d who spoke from fire that did not consume.

The last verse turns the agricultural blessing into a political one:

> *Bechor shoro hadar lo, vekarnei re'em karnav; bahem amim yenagach yachdav afsei aretz. His firstling bullock — majesty is his; his horns are the horns of the wild ox; with them he gores peoples, the ends of the earth together. They are the myriads of Ephraim and the thousands of Menashe. (33:17)*

Rashi identifies the firstling bull with Yehoshua, who came from Ephraim. Ibn Ezra and the Ramban stay closer to the image: strength that begins in the house of Yosef and reaches the edge of the map. Sforno hears the two kingdoms in the split of myriads and thousands — a blessing that already knows fracture and still assigns work to both sons.

Chassidus reads Yosef as *yesod*: the channel that joins what is above to what is below without mixing them. Dew is *hashpa'ah* that does not tear the ground. The tehom is the depth that would drown a man if it rose without measure. Yosef's gift is to receive both and remain a land — a bounded place that can feed brothers.

Shochni sneh binds the blessing to Moshe's first encounter. The bush is not Sinai. It is the lower fire, in a thorn, in a midbar, before the tablets. Favor that begins there is favor that knows exile. Yosef lived that favor in Egypt. The blessing of 18 Tishrei is not a wish for ease. It is a wish that the land remain capable of holding heaven and the deep at once.

Traditional approaches diverge on the force of verse 17. Some hear military charge. Some hear the later work of Yehoshua. Some, with the Midrash, hear Yosef's own refusal to dominate his brothers after he could have done so. The constructive synthesis for Chol HaMoed is this: power is given, and it is horned; it is also placed under *retzon Shochni sneh*. The ox is not self-authorizing. The blessing that fills barns is the same blessing that answers from a bush.

III. Tehillim 88–89: The Night Psalm and the Chesed of David

Psalm 88 is the darkest song in the book. No turn. No last-line rescue. *Heshbachtani bebor tachtiyot* — You have set me in the pit of the lower places. It is permitted, in the middle of Sukkot, to say a psalm that does not resolve. The sukkah is a shelter, not a denial.

Psalm 89 answers without erasing 88. *Chasdei Hashem olam ashirah.* The covenant with David is sung as chesed that outlasts the apparent collapse of the throne. The psalm itself then records the collapse: the crown profaned, the walls broken. It does not pretend the covenant has already been cashed. It holds the promise against the ruin.

Read together on Chai Tishrei, the two psalms are a circuit. You do not skip 88 to reach 89. You walk the dark letters and you still arrive at *baruch Hashem le'olam amen ve'amen*. Hoshanot work the same way. The circuit is not valid if it stops before *tav*.

IV. Tanya, Iggeret HaKodesh 22 (middle): A Loud Voice and a Simple Will

The Alter Rebbe writes as a man who cannot put his whole heart on the page. Occupations surround him like water. He therefore repeats what matters: those who volunteer beyond the measure should stand in the avodah of tefillah — service of the heart — *bekol ram*, with a loud voice, with a strong hand, against every inner and outer obstacle.

This, he says, is *retzon yere'av*, the will of those who fear Him. It stands above the chochmah and tevunah that Hashem has already given. Intellect is a gift. Will, in this register, is the yoke a person takes. *Ratzon pashut* — a simple will, uncompounded by the forms that intellect generates — and a *ruach nedivah*, a willing spirit, in anyone whose heart moves him to a whole service, to give nachat ruach to his Maker.

On that will the verse turns: *ki am keshei oref hu, vesalachta* — because they are a stiff-necked people, You shall pardon. Pardon, too, is above chochmah. Wisdom, asked what to do with a sinning soul, answered with judgment. Moshe asked *middah keneged middah*: let the simple will of return call down the simple will of pardon.

The seasonal join is exact. Hayom Yom asks for a complete circuit and for *hosha'ana* said aloud on the letters the shaliach tzibbur raises. Tanya asks for prayer with a raised voice and a will that does not wait for a full theory of itself. The willow, in the Rebbe's reading of the Four Species, is the Jew of simple faith. Today the willow is not an accessory. It is the day's thesis.

V. Rambam: Mikvaot 2–4 and Positive Commandment 109

Hilchot Mikvaot at this point in the cycle treats *chatzitzah* — intervening substance — and the measures by which water gathers, joins, or is disqualified. Immersion requires that water meet the whole body. A film the person would mind, a crust, a closed fist against the water, can hold impurity in place even when the person has gone down into the pool.

P109 states the mitzvah: *verachatz et kol besaro bamayim* — he shall bathe all his flesh in water. The Oral Law fixes the volume at forty se'ah for a gathered pool, and allows a living spring even in smaller measure for certain cases. The Rambam notes that the command is not an independent daily obligation for every impure person at every hour. It is the only gate back to taharah when a person chooses to enter the places that require it.

Chol HaMoed already lives inside a different water: *ushavtem mayim besason*. The nisuch hamayim of the Temple and the joy of the drawing are not identical with the mikveh, but they rhyme. Water that is not manufactured by the hand in the wrong way; water that must touch the whole; water that does not need to be understood in order to cleanse. Tanya's simple will and Rambam's unobstructed body are one discipline in two languages.

Gerushin 8, on the one-chapter track, continues the law of bills of divorce — speech and document that actually sever, or fail to. On a day of circuits and blessings it is a useful counterweight. Not every formula does the work it claims. Intention, wording, and delivery have to meet. Covenant is not a mood.

VI. Hayom Yom: Two Hymns, One Circuit, Through Tav

The entry is technical, and therefore spiritual.

Because 15 Tishrei can fall on Shabbat — as it did in 5704, the year behind the Hayom Yom, and as it did this year, 5787 — a day's Hoshanah may be omitted. The next available weekday takes both hymns and still walks only one hakafah. Nothing needed is dropped. Nothing extra is performed as theater. The community absorbs the missed word without doubling the feet.

Daily practice around that exception:

1. *Hosha'ana* before and after the phrases the chazzan chants aloud; once only on the rest.
2. The loud recitation begins at *samech* or *ayin*.
3. The circuit must be complete. It ends at *tav*.

The Rebbe's later teaching on the willow belongs here. The aravah is described as having neither taste nor fragrance — neither Torah nor ma'asim tovim in the usual accounting. That description cannot be only a slight. *Af poshei Yisrael mele'im mitzvot kerimon.* The Rayatz's language is sharper and kinder: simple Jews, whose observance is simple faith. When the kahal asks for *hoshiah na* and *hatzlichah na*, it highlights that quality. The circuit that stops before *tav* is a circuit that has left someone out.

Moshe, today's ushpiza, is the one who would not leave the camp even when he could have stood in a private cloud. The Mitteler Rebbe would not leave *binah* as a private possession. Completing the circuit is their middah in the feet.

VII. Approaches and a Constructive Synthesis

Peshat. Yosef's portion is blessed with unusual fertility and with political strength through Yehoshua. Hoshanot are the weekday continuation of the Temple circuit of willows around the altar (Mishnah Sukkah 4:5). Mikveh is the halachic gate of taharah.

Remez / Chassidus. Yosef is the yesod that holds dew and tehom. *Ratzon pashut* is the stiff neck that can be forgiven because it can also bow. The willow is simple faith bound into the lulav so that the four kinds are one body.

Breslov on this yahrtzeit. *Mitzvah gedolah lihyot besimchah.* Despair is the only closed gate. A psalm as dark as 88 is still a psalm — still speech toward Hashem.

Synthesis. Chai Tishrei asks for life that does not edit the record. Dew and deep. 88 and 89. Two hymns, one walk. A loud voice without a complicated self-story. Water on the whole body. Blessing that can gore at the ends of the earth and still answers to the bush.

VIII. Covenantal-Republican Resonance

The text supplies the civic line. It does not need a frame laid on top of it.

Yosef's horns are real, and they are blessed under *retzon Shochni sneh*. Authority in Israel is never self-sourced. That is non-domination in the older tongue: no human office is final.

The hakafah is a public act. A complete circuit is a picture of a people that refuses to leave its simple members outside the altar's walk. Republican life that is only for the fluent is not covenantal life.

Mikveh and get both insist that form matters. Consent, purity, and severance cannot be waved into being by private feeling. Limited power under higher law is first a discipline of deeds.

Free will in Tanya is not consumer choice. It is the capacity to generate a simple will that intellect cannot produce and then to stand in it *bekol ram*. That is the ground of return, and the ground of any genuine public consent.

IX. Practical Avodah

One focus for the day: **finish the circuit.**

In shul, walk the hakafah until *tav*. Do not treat the last letters as leftover. If you daven without a minyan, say the day's Hoshanah to the last letter anyway.

In tefillah, take the Alter Rebbe at his word for one amidah or one Hallel: a raised voice, a strong hand against the inner obstacle, without waiting to feel prepared.

In the sukkah, name Moshe as the guest. Let the children hear that the man of the Tent blessed Yosef's land, and that blessing includes dew they can see and a deep they cannot.

If R. Nachman's day reaches the table, keep it short: speak to Hashem in your own words once before sleep. That is enough.

X. Chinuch / Family

- The Four Species are a bundle so that the willow is not left alone. Ask: who in this family is the quiet one, and how do we bind him in?
- Dew falls; the deep sits under the ground. Yosef's brachah is both. We thank for what we see and for what holds us up.
- Why one extra Hoshanah and only one walk? Because Shabbat already took a day's song, and we do not leave a song unsung — and we do not make a show of walking twice.
- Psalm 88 is allowed. A child may know that some prayers are sad and still count.

XI. Closing

Moshe stands in the sukkah. Yosef's land is named. The kahal walks once, with two hymns if the calendar requires it, and does not stop before *tav*. The Alter Rebbe asks for a simple will and a loud voice. The mikveh asks for a body with no intervening film. R. Nachman asks for joy that does not wait on circumstances.

Chai Tishrei is not a slogan. It is a completed circle in a temporary house, under a roof you did not plaster, with a guest who already spoke with a bush.

Ushavtem mayim besason. Draw, and finish the walk.

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